Describing Trends:

Possible adjectives	Possible nouns	Possible verbs	Possible adverbs
gradual	variation	rise	gradually
moderate	decline	jump	moderately
modest	decrease	grow	modestly
sharp	dip	climb	sharply
dramatic	drop	increase	dramatically
slight	fall	rocket	slightly
steep	peak	fall	steeply
steady	fluctuation	drop	steadily
significant	growth	decline	significantly
considerable	increase	decrease	considerably
rapid	rise	go down	rapidly
	slump	plummet	slowly
		plunge	

Summarizing\Overview:

Your overview paragraph should contain two or three sentences summarizing the main features of the graph. To help you do this, here are some short phrases.

- To summarize, the most marked change is….
- Overall, it is clear….
- Overall, the majority/minority….
- In sum, the most noticeable trend is….

Don’t say ‘to conclude’. This is only for discursive essays.

Tense:

The key is to look at the chart's title and the information on both axes to establish what time frame is used. This will help you establish what tense you should use.

Example:

- If the time is one point in the past, for example, January 1990, then we should use the past tense.
- If it has projections for the future, for example, 2045, we use future tenses.
- If there is no time, we use the present simple.

Describing Increases and decreases:

1. Noun phrase + verb + adverb

Example:

- The price of property fell sharply
- The percentage of homes dropped dramatically.

2. There + be + noun + in + noun phrase

Example:

- There was a fall in literacy levels.
- There has been an increase in the cost of coffee.

3. Using fractions

Example:

- The price of oil halved in less than a year.
- The price of oil has halved since July.
- By July, the price of oil has halved.

Making Comparisons:

1. More/few/less + noun + than

Example:

- Overall, more people preferred public transport to taxis.

2. of one syllable -er + than

Example:

- A higher number of people preferred public transport to taxis.

3. More/less + adj. of more than one syllable + than

Example:

- Taxis were more popular than public transport.

4. of one syllable -est.

Example:

- The highest % of commuters preferred taxis.

5. The most/least + adj. of more than one syllable.

Example:

- The least popular mode of transport was buses.

Percentages and fractions:

You will have to deal with percentages in many of the IELTS writing task 1 questions. This is a good opportunity to express these percentages differently and boost your score. A way of varying this language is to express them as fractions or proportions.

Fractions

- 73%- nearly three quarters
- 51%- just over a half
- 49%- just under a half
- 32%- nearly a third
- 3%- a tiny fraction
- 50%- exactly a half
- 26%- roughly one quarter
- 49%- around a half
- 24%- almost a quarter
- 77%- approximately three quarters

Proportions

- 70%- a large proportion
- 71%- a significant majority
- 15% a small minority
- 3%- an insignificant minority